comparable to that of Margilan. This town stood handsomely at a high altitude. The Syr River coursed picturesquely on the northern side of the town. To its north and the Syr, lay the handsome mountain range of Munughul. As per the popular saying, Munughul was full of turquoise and other mines. People feared going to the mountain as it was full of snakes. Like Andijān, the hunting and fowling grounds of Khujand were full of pheasants and rabbits. It has been said that the climate of the place was conducive to malaria which many contracted, and Babur mentioned the mounts of Munghul to be the source of the same.

Khujand had a dependable village named Kand-i-Badam (Village of the Almond) 18 miles to its east. Though it was not a town, its significance lay in being an approach to an important town. As the name suggests, the almonds of this place were excellent and were exported to Hormuz. On to those 18 miles lay a wasteland known as Ha Darwesh, where the speedy wind blew all the time, travelling to Margilan from the east and towards Khujand from the west. This wind was indeed violent and turbulent. As per local sayings, some dervishes[14] had been lost to the turbulent wind. They kept calling, ‘Ha Darwesh! Ha Darwesh,’ till all of them perished. It was from then that the place came to be known as Ha Darwesh.

In the north of Syr River, lay the township of Akhsi. Babur mentions that the available literature of that period called it Akhsikit.[15] It was the second-largest township of Ferghana after Andijān, lying to its west. It was made into the capital city by Babur’s father, Umar Shaikh Mīrzā.

The Syr River flew below its walled town of Qurghan. It overlooked a great ravine that was used instead of the convention of moats. It was believed that no fort was as strong as Akhsi in the whole of Ferghana. The suburbs of Akhsi extended a couple of miles further from the walled town. People considered it as the most ideal in every respect. The melons of Akhsi seemed to be the best among all. A type of melon called Mir Timuri was considered sweeter than any other in the world. Although the melons of Bukhara were way more famous than those of Akhsi, Babur found no comparison in them. Certainly, Mir Timuri was the winner. Like Andijān and Khunjad, hunting and fowling was an apt retreat here too with abundant hare and pheasants all around.

To the north of Akhsi lay another town of Ferghana called Kasan. It was way smaller than the other towns. One could get the Akhsi water from Kasan, the same way as one could get Andijān water from Osh. Kasan was